

GOING UNDER
Video grab of a bridge collapsing into the Bakra River in the Sikti block of Araria district, June 18

BIHAR

UNABRIDGED DISASTERS

By Amitabh Srivastava

Politicians are always careful not to burn bridges with their electorate, but Bihar's collapsing bridges are making that unavoidable—one by one. Like a video playing in reverse, these structural failures capture setbacks to the state's infrastructure, undoing years of progress in just a matter of moments.

Since Nitish Kumar assumed office as chief minister in November 2005, Bihar has built over 6,200 bridges, small and big, symbolising a significant leap forward in infrastructure. But the past month has unveiled a disconcerting reality—between June 18 and July 4, at least 12 bridges crumbled across the districts of Kishanganj, Araria, Madhubani, East Champaran, Siwan and Saran. Many of these bridges are fairly new or were under construction. Initial investigations in Siwan and Saran suggest deeper systemic flaws, with some cases possibly exacerbated by the actions of inept departments.

Sources in the state water resources department (WRD) acknowledge that the unprofessional execution of the river-linking project under the Jal-Jeevan-Hariyali initiative may have contributed to some bridge collapses. Desilting operations as part of the initiative inadvertently damaged structures due to technical oversights and inadequate coordination. For example, before the monsoon, the WRD initiated embankment-strengthening efforts to mitigate the impact of the Chhoti Gandak river's overflow in the Gopalganj, Siwan and Saran districts. This involved desilting approximately